

The Yellow Wallpaper

Charlotte Perkins Gilman · 1892

First published: The New England Magazine, Jan 1892

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Yellow_Wall_Paper (revision 15679493), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Yellow Wallpaper suggest about women and medical authority?
- What does The Yellow Wallpaper suggest about confinement and madness?
- What does The Yellow Wallpaper suggest about voice and silence?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Yellow Wallpaper	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*women and medical authority* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Yellow Wallpaper

Focus: confinement driving a woman into madness

Content note (postpartum depression and psychosis, controlling marriage, suicide): Sensitive content: Postpartum depression and psychosis; controlling marriage. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes postpartum depression and psychosis; controlling marriage. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this story is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

A woman recovering from what her physician husband John calls a 'temporary nervous depression' after childbirth keeps a secret journal during a summer 'rest cure' in an old mansion. Forbidden to write or work, she is confined to a nursery with barred windows and hideous yellow wallpaper. She comes to see a woman trapped behind its pattern. On the last night she tears the paper off to free her, identifies with her, and creeps around the room; John faints at the sight.

Background: Gilman (1892) based it on her own treatment by S. Weir Mitchell, whose 'rest cure' forbade intellectual work. She said she wrote it to save people from being driven crazy.

Significance: A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes postpartum depression and psychosis; controlling marriage. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are splintered, congenial, journeys, provoking, humiliating. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars." In this sentence it means: broken into sharp pieces. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Yellow Wallpaper would have known. Gilman (1892) based it on her own treatment by S. Weir Mitchell, whose 'rest cure' forbade intellectual work. She said she wrote it to save people from being driven crazy. Why does this story matter? A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for point of view.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "I never saw so much expression in an inanimate thing before, and we all know how much expression they have!" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to confinement driving a woman into madness? I circle "entertainment", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find point of view, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for point of view.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of point of view. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *I never saw so much expression in an inanimate thing before, and we all know how much expression they have! I used to lie awake as a child and get more entertainment and terror out of blank walls and plain furniture than most children could find in a toy-store.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Point of view, Symbolism, Imagery: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Yellow Wallpaper develops the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to women and medical authority? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about confinement driving a woman into madness, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes confinement driving a woman into madness. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
splintered (verb)	broken into sharp pieces	*Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
congenial (adjective)	pleasant and well suited	*Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
journeys (noun)	the act of traveling from one place to another	*So I take phosphates or phosphites,—whichever it is,—and tonics, and journeys, and air, and exercise, and am absolutely forbidden to "work" until I am well again.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
provoking (verb)	call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)	*But in the places where it isn't faded, and where the sun is just so, I can see a strange, provoking, formless sort of figure, that seems to sulk about behind that silly and conspicuous front design.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
humiliating (verb)	cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of	*It must be very humiliating to be caught creeping by daylight!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
excuses (noun)	a defense of some offensive behavior or	*Ihave watched John when he did not know I was looking, and come into the room suddenly on the most*	

	some failure to keep a promise etc.	*innocent excuses, and I've caught him several times looking at the paper!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tiresome (adjective)	so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness	*In the daytime it is tiresome and perplexing.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
studying (verb)	observing closely	*But I know she was studying that pattern, and I am determined that nobody shall find it out but myself!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
entertainment (noun)	an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention	*I used to lie awake as a child and get more entertainment and terror out of blank walls and plain furniture than most children could find in a toy-store.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with women and medical authority?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the narrator's husband's job? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Physician
2. What is the narrator forbidden to do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Work and write
3. In which room is the narrator kept? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An upstairs nursery with barred windows
4. What does she see behind the wallpaper's pattern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A woman creeping and trapped
5. How does the story end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: John faints and she creeps over him
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Yellow Wallpaper” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A woman recovering from what her physician husband John calls a 'temporary nervous depression' after childbirth keeps a secret journal during a summer 'rest cure' in an old mansion. Forbidden to write or work, she is confined to a nursery with barred windows and hideous yellow wallpaper. She comes to see a woman trapped behind its pattern. On the last night she tears the paper off to free her,…

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Yellow Wallpaper”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Yellow Wallpaper” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.” What does “splintered” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: splintered: broken into sharp pieces.
10. Reread: “Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.” What does “congenial” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: congenial: pleasant and well suited.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Yellow Wallpaper” suggest about confinement driving a woman into madness? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about confinement driving a woman into madness? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “I never saw so much expression in an inanimate thing before, and we all know how much expression they have!”, why might Gilman have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Yellow Wallpaper”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A woman recovering from what her physician husband John calls a 'temporary nervous depression' after childbirth keeps a secret journal during a summer 'rest cure' in an old mansion. Forbidden to write or work, she is confined to a nursery with barred windows and hideous yellow wallpaper. She comes…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Yellow Wallpaper” set up that the rest of The Yellow Wallpaper will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with women and medical authority? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
10. Background: Gilman (1892) based it on her own treatment by S. Weir Mitchell, whose 'rest cure' forbade intellectual work. She said she wrote it to save people from being driven crazy. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Yellow Wallpaper" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about confinement driving a woman into madness? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Yellow Wallpaper": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to confinement and madness: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Gilman need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Yellow Wallpaper" treats confinement driving a woman into madness with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Yellow Wallpaper see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve women and medical authority? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about confinement driving a woman into madness? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Charlotte Perkins Gilman about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. What is the narrator's husband's job?
   A. Physician
   B. Lawyer
   C. Minister
   D. Banker
2. What is the narrator forbidden to do?
   A. Work and write
   B. See her baby at all
   C. Leave the country
   D. Eat meat
3. In which room is the narrator kept?
   A. The library
   B. The parlor
   C. The cellar
   D. An upstairs nursery with barred windows
4. What does she see behind the wallpaper's pattern?
   A. A woman creeping and trapped
   B. Words
   C. A map
   D. A face of her mother
5. How does the story end?
   A. She escapes
   B. She burns the house
   C. She is cured
   D. John faints and she creeps over him
6. In the line “Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.”, what does “splintered” most nearly mean?
   A. broken into sharp pieces
   B. the act of traveling from one place to another
   C. pleasant and well suited
   D. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)

7. In the line “Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.”, what does “congenial” most nearly mean?
   A. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
   B. the act of traveling from one place to another
   C. pleasant and well suited
   D. broken into sharp pieces

Answer key: 1. A (Physician); 2. A (Work and write); 3. D (An upstairs nursery with barred windows); 4. A (A woman creeping and trapped); 5. D (John faints and she creeps over him); 6. A (broken into sharp pieces); 7. C (pleasant and well suited)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Yellow Wallpaper,” how does Gilman show confinement driving a woman into madness? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Yellow Wallpaper, how does Gilman develop the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Yellow Wallpaper develops the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of confinement driving a woman into madness. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Yellow Wallpaper suggests about confinement driving a woman into madness. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Charlotte Perkins Gilman uses point of view in The Yellow Wallpaper to complicate the reader's understanding of confinement driving a woman into madness. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Yellow Wallpaper within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of confinement driving a woman into madness responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Yellow Wallpaper alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of confinement driving a woman into madness follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Yellow Wallpaper and its treatment of confinement driving a woman into madness. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Yellow Wallpaper as evidence for a larger claim about confinement driving a woman into madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Yellow Wallpaper as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of confinement driving a woman into madness. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Yellow Wallpaper.

SAT-style questions

1. *So I take phosphates or phosphites,—whichever it is,—and tonics, and journeys, and air, and exercise, and am absolutely forbidden to "work" until I am well again.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “journeys” most nearly mean?

   A. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention

   B. observing closely

   C. so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness

   D. the act of traveling from one place to another

2. *I never saw so much expression in an inanimate thing before, and we all know how much expression they have! I used to lie awake as a child and get more entertainment and terror out of blank walls and plain furniture than most children could find in a toy-store.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Yellow Wallpaper”?

   A. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   B. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

   C. Confinement driving a woman into madness

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. D (the act of traveling from one place to another); 2. C (Confinement driving a woman into madness)

Whole-book test

The Yellow Wallpaper: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What is the narrator's husband's job?
   A. Physician
   B. Lawyer
   C. Minister
   D. Banker
2. What is the narrator forbidden to do?
   A. Work and write
   B. See her baby at all
   C. Leave the country
   D. Eat meat
3. In which room is the narrator kept?
   A. The library
   B. The parlor
   C. The cellar
   D. An upstairs nursery with barred windows
4. What does she see behind the wallpaper's pattern?
   A. A woman creeping and trapped
   B. Words
   C. A map
   D. A face of her mother
5. How does the story end?
   A. She escapes
   B. She burns the house
   C. She is cured
   D. John faints and she creeps over him
6. In the line “Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.”, what does “splintered” most nearly mean?
   A. broken into sharp pieces
   B. the act of traveling from one place to another
   C. pleasant and well suited
   D. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)

7. In the line “Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.”, what does “congenial” most nearly mean?
   A. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
   B. the act of traveling from one place to another
   C. pleasant and well suited
   D. broken into sharp pieces
8. As used in the story (“Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all ”), what does “splintered” mean?
   A. broken into sharp pieces
   B. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
   C. observing closely
   D. the act of traveling from one place to another
9. As used in the story (“Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.”), what does “congenial” mean?
   A. a defense of some offensive behavior or some failure to keep a promise etc.
   B. pleasant and well suited
   C. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention
   D. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
10. As used in the story (“So I take phosphates or phosphites,—whichever it is,—and tonics, and journeys, and air, and exercise, and am absolutely forbidden to "work" ”), what does “journeys” mean?
    A. so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness
    B. broken into sharp pieces
    C. the act of traveling from one place to another
    D. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
11. As used in the story (“But in the places where it isn't faded, and where the sun is just so, I can see a strange, provoking, formless sort of figure, that seems to”), what does “provoking” mean?
    A. observing closely
    B. pleasant and well suited
    C. a defense of some offensive behavior or some failure to keep a promise etc.
    D. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
12. As used in the story (“It must be very humiliating to be caught creeping by daylight!”), what does “humiliating” mean?
    A. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
    B. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention
    C. the act of traveling from one place to another
    D. so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how women and medical authority develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how confinement and madness develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how voice and silence develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (women and medical authority, confinement and madness, voice and silence) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (Physician); 2. A (Work and write); 3. D (An upstairs nursery with barred windows); 4. A (A woman creeping and trapped); 5. D (John faints and she creeps over him); 6. A (broken into sharp pieces); 7. C (pleasant and well suited); 8. A (broken into sharp pieces); 9. B (pleasant and well suited); 10. C (the act of traveling from one place to another); 11. D (call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)); 12. A (cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of)

Essay assignments

Essay: Women and medical authority

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Yellow Wallpaper teaches about women and medical authority. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops women and medical authority across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of women and medical authority. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charlotte Perkins Gilman's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of women and medical authority, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Yellow Wallpaper's treatment of women and medical authority in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper. Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Confinement and madness

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Yellow Wallpaper teaches about confinement and madness. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops confinement and madness across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of confinement and madness. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charlotte Perkins Gilman's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of confinement and madness, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Yellow Wallpaper's treatment of confinement and madness in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Voice and silence

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Yellow Wallpaper teaches about voice and silence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops voice and silence across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of voice and silence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charlotte Perkins Gilman's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of voice and silence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Yellow Wallpaper's treatment of voice and silence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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